[i] In the 1820s the East India Company spent a massive Rs 5,000 in buying the journal of one of these officers, General Claude August Court, in which he described his overland journey through Afghanistan.

[j] It is a book written by James Burnes, *A Sketch of the History of the Knight's Templars* (1840), that first links the Freemasons to the Templars and Roslyn Chapel near Edinburgh. It is the ultimate progenitor of a wash of popular nonsense like *The Holy Blood and the Holy Grail* and *The Da Vinci Code*.

[k] For more on Henry Russell, see my *White Mughals* (London, 2002).

[l] The same title was later taken by Mullah Omar of the Taliban who in 1996 looked explicitly to the example of Dost Mohammad for inspiration for the founding of the Taliban Islamic Amirate of Afghanistan.

[m] The hunky male eighteen-year-old Chippendales of Islamic heaven, counterparts to the supermodel houris.

[n] The selective editing of Burnes's despatches for the Blue Book in order to win Parliamentary approval for the war later became a major scandal, the 'dodgy dossier' of its day. See G. R. Alder, 'The Garbled Blue Books of 1839', *Historical Journal*, vol. XV, no. 2 (1972), pp. 229–59.

[o] Home of the future Bhutto dynasty.

[p] This at least is what Nesselrode told Palmerston. In reality it is clear that Simonitch was ready to rejoin the beautiful Princess Orbeliani and their ten children in Tiflis. Since the murder of Griboyedov, a previous Russian envoy to Iran, the Teheran Legation had been considered unsafe for spouses or children, much like the British and American embassies in modern Pakistan. After Simonitch's return to Georgia, his successor Duhamel initially took a similar diplomatic line to Simonitch.

[q] This has become a famous line and is widely remembered even today. In 2003 it was repeated to me by Javed Paracha, a wily Pashtun lawyer who has successfully defended al-Qaeda suspects in the Peshawar High Court. In his fortress-like stronghouse in Kohat, deep in the lawless tribal belt that acts as a buffer between Pakistan and Afghanistan, Paracha had sheltered wounded Taliban fighters – and their frost-bitten women and children – fleeing across the mountains from the American daisy-cutters at Tora Bora, and was twice imprisoned in the notorious prison at Dera Ismail Khan. There he was kept in solitary while being questioned – and he alleges tortured – by CIA interrogators. Despite seeing at close quarters what modern western weaponry was capable of, he knew his history, and never believed NATO would succeed in its occupation of Afghanistan. When I went to interview him in Kohat soon after the installation of President Karzai he quoted Mehrab Khan's line to me as evidence of the futility of the attempt to install another Popalzai in power.

[r] The land appears to be much drier today – the 'Dasht which stretches from Spin Boldak at the foot of the mountains south of Kandahar is now a virtual desert with only a little spring grazing and the dwarf oaks confined to the mountain slopes. But the descriptions left by members of the Army of the